Interview Activity

Regan Reed

UNC – Chapel Hill

EDUC 590: Special Topics

Dr. Barnshaw

October 7th, 2026

For this assignment, I interviewed two professionals who work within entrepreneurship and education in different settings. My first interview was with Naomi Burns, who is a Program Manager at Launch Chapel Hill. Launch Chapel Hill is a nonprofit organization that supports entrepreneurs through accelerator programs, mentorship, and connections to resources throughout the Triangle. My second interview was with Ahmed Ali, who is a Program Director within the North Carolina State University Entrepreneurship Unit. His work focuses on providing students with co-curricular entrepreneurship opportunities and experiences outside of the traditional classroom. I chose to interview Naomi and Ahmed because their roles provided two different perspectives on entrepreneurship education. One perspective comes from an accelerator that works directly with founders, and the other comes from entrepreneurship programming within a university.

Launch Chapel Hill focuses on entrepreneurship education by giving students, local founders, and deep-tech founders opportunities to learn through experience. Naomi explained that while Launch does provide educational sessions with mentors and experienced business professionals, a lot of the learning happens when founders take that information and apply it to their own companies. The programs help founders learn about areas such as customer discovery, identifying the right customers, understanding willingness to pay, and communicating the value of their product. One thing Naomi emphasized was that Launch tries to meet founders where they are rather than taking the same approach with every company. Overall, Launch provides founders with education, mentorship, connections, and resources, while also giving them the responsibility to put in the work and apply what they learn.

NC State's Entrepreneurship Unit also focuses on entrepreneurship education, but its programs are centered around college students. Ahmed explained that the unit is not academic,

which gives it more flexibility to provide co-curricular learning opportunities outside of a traditional classroom. Their programs introduce students to entrepreneurship through ideation, mentorship, funding opportunities, leadership development, and connections with other students and experienced entrepreneurs. What I found interesting is that students do not need to already have a business or even a specific idea to participate. A lot of the programming is designed to expose students to entrepreneurship and help them develop ideas through their experiences and connections with others. The overall focus is not only to help students start businesses, but also to help them develop an entrepreneurial mindset that can be useful in different careers.

There were three main takeaways that stood out to me from both interviews. First, I learned how important learning through experience is within entrepreneurship education. Both Naomi and Ahmed talked about getting people outside of the traditional classroom and giving them opportunities to actually apply what they are learning. Naomi explained that Launch can provide educational sessions, mentors, and resources, but founders still have to take what they learn and apply it to their own companies. Ahmed described a similar approach at NC State, where students can participate in ideation, mentorship, leadership development, and other experiences outside of their classes. This showed me that entrepreneurship can be difficult to fully learn just by being taught the concepts. There is a lot of value in actually putting those concepts into practice.

My second takeaway was that entrepreneurship education is not only for people who want to start a business. Ahmed said one of their challenges is helping students understand that entrepreneurship is also about developing an entrepreneurial mindset. Even if a student wants to pursue a completely different career, they can still benefit from learning how to recognize opportunities, develop ideas, and think differently about problems. This stood out to me because

it made me think about entrepreneurship education as something that can benefit a much wider group of students.

Finally, I learned how important relationships and connections are within entrepreneurship. Naomi talked about connecting founders with mentors, customers, and other organizations throughout the Triangle. I thought it was especially interesting that Launch does not view every other accelerator or entrepreneurship organization as a competitor. If another organization can better support a founder, they are willing to make that connection. Ahmed also discussed the importance of connecting students with their peers because ideas can grow from those relationships. Both conversations showed me that entrepreneurship does not happen individually and that having the right community and connections can be an important part of developing an idea.

Both organizations have specific qualities that set them apart from other organizations in entrepreneurship education. Naomi explained that one of Launch Chapel Hill's biggest differences is that Launch Powered by KPMG operates as a customer accelerator. While many accelerator programs work with entrepreneurs who are still determining whether their idea has potential or completing customer discovery, Launch works with founders at a later stage. These founders have already developed a product and identified a need for it, so Launch focuses more on helping them gain early customers and build market traction. Launch's relationship with KPMG also allows the program to focus on companies selling to enterprise customers and help founders build connections in that area. Ahmed explained that NC State's approach is different because of the university's strong STEM and engineering focus. Many of the students and projects they work with come from the College of Engineering, which means their ideas can involve more technical or deep-science concepts. Because of this, NC State's entrepreneurship

programming has to understand both the entrepreneurial side of an idea and the technical knowledge behind it.

There are different aspects of both Naomi's and Ahmed's jobs that interest me. For Naomi, I found the variety within her role especially interesting. She talked about working directly with founders and following their progress, while also thinking about the larger entrepreneurial ecosystem and where new programs or resources might be needed. Since I am currently interning at Launch Chapel Hill, I have been able to see parts of their work myself, but hearing Naomi explain the bigger purpose behind it gave me a better understanding of how everything connects. I also like that her role combines relationship building, communication, program development, and entrepreneurship rather than focusing on only one area. Ahmed's role interested me for a different reason. I liked hearing about how he works directly with students and helps them think through their ideas, especially because he said that hearing students' business ideas is one of the most interesting parts of his job. I was also interested in his career path because he completed the MEITE program himself. Hearing him explain that the concepts he learned in MEITE gave him a foundation that he now uses in his career made his role feel especially relevant to me and the program I am currently completing.

These conversations definitely expanded my interest in this part of the education sector. Before the interviews, I understood entrepreneurship education mostly through my classes and my experience interning at Launch, but I had not thought as much about the different career opportunities that exist within this area. Talking with Naomi and Ahmed showed me that entrepreneurship education can look very different depending on the organization and the people served. It can involve working directly with founders, developing programs, mentoring students, building relationships, or creating opportunities for people to learn through experience. I was

especially interested in how both roles combine several areas I enjoy, including education, communication, innovation, and working with people. Ahmed's path from METITE into his current role also helped me see a more direct connection between what I am learning now and careers I could potentially explore after graduation. Overall, these interviews made me more interested in continuing to explore entrepreneurship and innovation as an area of the education sector.